

The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere: An Inquiry into a Category of Bourgeois Society. Jürgen Habermas. Translated by Thomas Burger with the assistance of Frederick Lawrence. Cambridge: MIT Press, 1989. Pp. xix + 301. \$35.00.

From its origins in Greek antiquity, the study of rhetoric has had two abiding concerns: the production of effective communication and the critique of discourse in public life. Certainly it is true that the techniques of inventing arguments and managing symbols have been the more historically evident of these concerns. For that reason the evolution of rhetorical studies, particularly during the last half of this century, could be seen as a radical departure from its ancestral roots. But such an interpretation would err by omitting the persistent debate in Western letters over the integrity of a politics that either includes or excludes rhetoric as essential to the ideals of the state. Moreover, it would be equally erroneous to diminish the importance of the current shift of emphasis in rhetorical studies that brings the concerns of social critique to the fore, as represented by the recent focus on rhetoric as a social practice. Indeed, the current renaissance of interest in rhetoric across the humanities and social sciences has been largely fuelled by the insight that humans live and experience social life as they do because they manage symbols as they do. Put differently, our social realities are rhetorically constituted. The benchmarks announcing rhetoric's extension into all aspects of social and political life are discernible, not least among them being the steadily growing influence of Kenneth Burke across and beyond letters, the political turmoil of the 1960s, the publication of *The Prospect of Rhetoric*, and the assimilation of contemporary Continental thought theorizing the relationship of discourse to society into rhetoric's own current theoretical developments and debates.

The last of these is especially noteworthy because it has been through the reflections on discourse by European intellectuals that rhetoricians have found the field of ideas within which to revive/revise/reformulate the role rhetoric plays in the formation of social

will. Jürgen Habermas has been a leading voice influencing this enterprise, with his development of a theory of communicative action intended to critique ideological distortion and to emancipate society from its domination. Central to his effort is his articulation of a theory of rational discourse. The seminal work with which he outlined the historical origination of the problem of democracy as residing in the very possibility for such discourse was published in 1962 as *Strukturwandel der Öffentlichkeit*. Its recent translation, which appears as *The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere*, makes available to English readers the most empirical and accessible of Habermas's studies, and provides an orientation of inestimable value to his intellectual project as a whole.

The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere is concerned with the possibilities for open discussion and deliberation by informed and interested members of society on matters that shape the policies and practices of the culture and the state. As such, it is a book about the possibility for democracy in the era of late capitalism. It traces the evolution of the public sphere from the enlightenment ideal of an open discursive space where ideas were freely exchanged and opinion formed to the period of the book's publication in the early 1960s.

The argument of the book is deceptively straightforward while advancing a complex and thoroughgoing critique of the consequences of capitalism on public life. Habermas contends that the bourgeois public sphere arose from the aesthetic and literary discussions of the enlightenment coffeehouses of England, salons of France, table societies of Germany. In these places, private individuals who had read engaged in open discussion of aesthetic and literary matters from which opinions were formed on the strength of the argument, "without regard to all preexisting social and political rank and in accord with universal rules" (54). The literary public sphere was open to all private individuals, including those not formally educated: "Female readers as well as apprentices and servants often took a more active part in the literary public sphere than owners of private property and family heads themselves" (56). The rise of book clubs, reading circles, and subscription libraries made the reading of novels common among the bourgeois. The discussions of works such as *Pamela* brought about a rational-critical discussion of the subjectivity that originated in the family. "By communicating with itself," Habermas claims, such subjectivity "attained clarity about itself" (51). The universal rule of admis-

sion leveled the authority of each to speak to this issue, regardless of rank, because the literary sphere had defined itself as the realm of humanity.

Early on, Habermas alerts the reader to the susceptibility to fantasy to which each age is prone in defining the boundaries and conditions for admission to the public sphere. Thus, while enlightenment ideology professed that the literary public sphere was open to all humanity, Habermas notes, the true criteria for admission were education and property, which most often defined one and the same populace. As soon as these private individuals ceased to communicate merely about their subjectivity and began to communicate as property owners in order to influence public power to protect their common economic interests, the literary public sphere began to function as a public sphere in the political realm. "*The fully developed bourgeois public sphere was based on the fictitious identity of the two roles assumed by the privatized individuals who came together to form a public: the role of property owners and the role of human beings, pure and simple*" (56, emphasis in original). While the fusion of education and property meant that in reality there were never two groups admitted to this sphere, the fictitious criterion of humanity eased the identification of property owners with common people as a single public, a fantasy facilitated further as the bourgeois public began to achieve positive political influence that carried common benefit.

The bourgeois public sphere was a place for educated and economically invested individuals to exchange views on matters of public life and, thereby, to form a public opinion that was to be taken seriously for shaping the ways in which these matters were disposed. Within the framework of the democratic state, the public sphere thus came to represent the domain from which legitimation for official action could be drawn. Habermas traces the transformations in the structure of this sphere as economic conditions change the role of private enterprise, the press, the state, and even the arts in publicizing matters pertaining to the common good and for the understanding of public opinion.

Originally, Habermas contends, the public sphere stood for the dissolution of power. Rather than providing a testimonial for approving state action, it signified that the state had no power that did not flow from the people. The public sphere, and the public it contained, were the seat of power. By the nineteenth century the rise of capitalism had infiltrated and reshaped the public sphere to

the extent that it now served the division of power, as public opinion became the upper limit on power. Now the state would turn to the public sphere not as the *connatus* for official action but as the source of legitimation for the acts it itself initiated. With this turn came the increasing need to control the public sphere to guarantee the sanction of public opinion. Finally, in the contemporary era, the bourgeois public sphere has been further transformed to a place ruled by laws of the market, in which information is treated as a commodity and the public as *clientele* who are the consumers of propaganda and spectacle rather than as participants in public discourses aimed at rational consensus.

The structural transformation Habermas is tracing is nowhere more evident than in the change that capitalism wrought on the literary public sphere. Habermas depicts this sphere as originally akin to the Athenian polis, ruled by open debate with reading as its only requirement to be taken seriously. "The bourgeois public's critical debate took place in principle without regard to all preexisting social and political rank and in accord with universal rules" (54). But as the literary public sphere became a realm of consumption, it degenerated from a space governed by rational-critical debate to one now governed by the laws of commodity exchange. As Habermas perceptively observes, while the enlightenment citizen had to pay for the concert, theatre, or book, conversation was free. Now such conversation is administered as a consumer item, staged on TV and at conferences one must pay to attend in order to observe experts exchange ideas. The economic market for cultural goods also distorts the availability and assessment of cultural artifacts. For example, book clubs create consumers for works of literature, thereby reducing the publisher's economic risks by guaranteeing an audience that must buy books to retain membership. Rather than a reading public, members become an administered *clientele* beyond the world of letters. Their choices are defined by the economic constraints of membership rather than by the informed discussion of literary productions, which further weakens the role of criticism in shaping public opinion.

Habermas argues that the constraints of such commodification on publicity have telling ramifications for our understanding of public opinion, the very cornerstone of legitimation in a democracy. The principle of publicity holds that the views of those who enter a public discussion should get the broadest possible circulation, so that they may be factored into the ongoing discourses to

which they pertain. Since Habermas presupposes that open discourse will produce truth, the principle of publicity insures that truth will be reflected in a public opinion based on rational-critical discourse and become the basis for public action. When discourse itself becomes a commodity, however, the public sphere no longer serves as the vessel for truth, since there no longer is unconstrained dissemination of ideas, only dissemination of that which has market value for economic gain. Public opinion now becomes a threatened product subject to the manipulation of information intended to arouse an artificial but politically expedient response required for legitimation of state action. The structural transformation of the bourgeois public sphere finally has made public opinion itself a commodity that remains the object of domination of the governmental and administrative structures of a social-welfare state.

There is much to admire in Habermas's analysis of the bourgeois public sphere: the carefully constructed argument linking aesthetics to politics, the systematic development of the tension between public and private life, the critique of the dissolution of publicity and public opinion from principles supporting open discussion aimed at rational-critical decision making, and all with telling effect on the present discontents of public discourse in a distorted public sphere. Still, there are reasons to hold that Habermas's analysis should not be accepted without reservation. I wish to mention three briefly.

First, Habermas seems to equate the functioning of the bourgeois public sphere with the discursive domain of opinion formation from which the state derives its legitimation. But on the face of it, this privileges the discourses of the propertied and educated to steer the course of a democracy. It does not take into account the discourses, say, of laborers who, while they may lack the degree of education or the extent of property as the bourgeois, nonetheless have struggled to organize in order to influence the policies of institutions that affect their lives. Are we to exclude the union hall and factory floor from the public sphere? And what are we to say of women, who were excluded from the public sphere until recently, and yet have a long history of establishing alternative spheres of discourse in which to discover common interests and shape opinion? Habermas's formulation provides little opportunity for those who are out of the political mainstream to participate in a democracy. This would appear to pose a

significant problem for generalizing from his analysis to the more inclusive characteristics of the public sphere on which a democratic politics can be assessed.

Second, Habermas insists that the principle of the public sphere requires the guarantee of the state for it to exist. Perhaps this analysis is overly colored by his own experiences with the politics of a divided Germany at the time he first wrote this work. Certainly the resistance movements of World War II, the *samizdat* literature of the former Soviet Union, the formation and then survival of Solidarity in Poland, and the political events of 1989 in central Europe all stand as evidence that a public sphere can exist underground. It may not have the power to authorize state action, but it can and did have the power to support rational-critical deliberation through which common interests were discovered and a public opinion was formed. Moreover, even though functioning under serious constraints, this opinion was publicized to all who cared to learn of it, spread, gained allegiance, and provided a basis for common action leading to a series of "velvet" revolutions in which all who participated knew their parts. More significant than its institutional guarantee to exist is the public sphere's definitive characteristic as a discursive space. Even under the most severe handicaps, it is possible for open deliberations to transpire. Even under the most secure guarantees, it is possible for absolute distortion to prevail. I would contend that discursive qualities rather than institutional guarantees determine whether deliberations are open or distorted.

Third, Habermas's analysis leads to the conclusion that the public sphere is moribund at best, and perhaps a victim of the inequitable distribution of wealth and power that arose during the industrialization of Europe and America. One is tempted to say that his analysis grows from an analysis of discourse at once too narrow in its understanding of how publics are formed and legitimate action and too reliant on economic factors to define political relations. Regretably, Habermas has an emaciated understanding of rhetoric and its function in social praxis, and it shows. Put differently, there is a presupposition that an ideal form of communication should ground a democracy. But democracies have never had an easy relationship between the masses and the wealthy elite. Although it may be true that the people reign, it is also true historically that elites rule. Democracies are not immune from struggles to appropriate historicity between those with power and those without.

Viewed from the perspective of economic advantage, it would appear that Europe and America are dominated by commercial interests who manipulate the masses to insure wealth and solidify power. But by tending to the rhetoric of those not in power one finds an alternative reading of society, one alive with activity of resistance, defining alternative visions of social and political relations, and seeking actively to gain adherents to effect change. A concept of the public sphere with traction on the discursive (and, therefore, social and political, definitively processual) realities of the present day must be alert not to fall prey to an ideological analysis that is insensitive to this ongoing struggle by which society produces itself.

These caveats notwithstanding, Habermas's analysis is a monumental achievement. The current intellectual foment concerning rhetoric has centered on the sociological and epistemological implications of discourse. Among the central issues being addressed is the cluster of problems related to the formation and role of publics, including the tension between public and private, the nature of publics, the understanding of public opinion, and the possibility of a public sphere. In some respects, current thought on these matters has incorporated what is best in Habermas's analysis, and through critique of his position advanced the frontiers for conceptualizing publics beyond the possibilities offered by its bourgeois manifestation. Yet the power of the conceptual framework presented in *The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere* for informing our thought about and understanding of the possibility for political discourse in western states can only be described as seminal. While rhetoricians justifiably may read this book as in the tradition of its ancient concern with discourse as informing of politics, they will find here an alternative framework for grounding the very possibility of a democratic society in discourse: more sensitive to the political realities of late capitalism, more suitable for tracing its vertiginous alterations in a mass mediated age. It is a work that cannot be ignored by any serious student of the role of rhetoric in shaping public and private life.

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